

# THINKING MEAT!\*

**Disrupter:** Maker tech

**Disrupted:** Traditional tech companies

**What Year:** Already happening

**R**ecently we've covered the maker revolution in stories and even in this month's Fast Track. Why? Because with the digital age come digital children. Kids born in the last 15 years have always known technology to be a part of their lives. Sure there have been improvements, but by and large, technology is not this alien thing to be poked at suspiciously. Most of our grandparents (and quite a few parents) fall into this category of the non-tech-enabled generations. Many of them have learned and adapted, true, but it is still alien to them. It's like you learning to speak another language on your own as an adult – sure some will manage beautifully, but most will never be anywhere as good as those who grew up speaking that language.

It's the same for the digital age kids. They are just so much more fluent in geek, that they can't help being coders and makers. We see the future of technology as being driven by individuals, for individuals. You will write or modify apps to your liking, and then share that

data, and then someone will further modify that to suit themselves, etc. It's the open source project, but on steroids, and with a more selfish goal – to keep yourself happy and productive.

Already the simplified app creators exist, so that many can build their own simple apps. Want an app that pulls various RSS feeds and throws them together to look like a professional news app? You don't need to code it from scratch, there are tonnes of free or paid app builders that will do the job for you in a jiffy. You can literally have an app in a day, and it will look pretty personalised too. Goodbarber is an example that this writer has used, but there are hundreds. Wix allows you to build responsive, mobile-friendly sites, and quickly. It's also just one amongst hundreds.

However, all this is best for the older generations who don't know how to code, and just want point and click creator tools. The next generation is not going to need any of these. They will build on top of much more complex apps, and help better the personalised experience.



GoodBarber lets you easily make apps

What does this do for the evolution of technology? Think adrenaline injection directly to the heart. What we're going to get is literally smart networked individuals processing their own little problems, but adding up to an insane amount of maker power. A human supercomputer of sorts, where every human is crunching the problems unique to him / her, but in doing so, is solving over 75 per cent of the problems that a heck of a lot of other people also share.

This human supercomputer will outperform the biggest and best supercomputers by orders of magnitude, because it will have individual human creativity, which machines don't. However, in order to achieve this on a much bigger and badder scale than is already happening now, we will need the next disruption to occur...

# THE MATRIX

**Disrupter:** Free Internet

**Disrupted:** ISPs, Traditional businesses, potentially everything...

**What Year:** 2018 to 2025

**E**ventually, in some form or the other, we really do need to get everyone on to the internet because a kid in a remote village in Africa or India might have the smarts to cure cancer or solve climate change, if only he or she was given a proper formal education, and allowed to get creative with knowledge...

Yes, all of us at Digit are very well aware that Internet.org, Project Loon and Elon Musk's satellites are all commercial enterprises with very long term rewards. We didn't go ga-ga over Facebook's reason

for supporting digital India, and we know that PM Modi's meeting with Zuckerberg was a business meeting.

Still...

Does it hurt to let Facebook go from 1 billion users to 3, so long as those 2 more billion get some access to the internet? Facebook's rebranded "Free Basics" might be a scam in the making. Sure 1.99 billion of them will just poke one another and share silly forwards, but it's that 1 per cent that interests us. Of course they may be locked into "Facebook's version of the Internet", at first, but do you really believe

that smart people will be satisfied with that? Would you be?

You know, for a fact, that had you been stuck with Facebook's firewalls, you'd find a way to get access to more. VPNs, TOR, tunnelling, whatever it would take. Even paying for an ISP of your own. Just as no one can suppress your hunger of tech, Facebook, Google and SpaceX can only do good by getting kids to discover the internet. Will they get rich from doing so? Of course they will. Is that a bad enough reason to let half the world live in oblivion? Hell no.